

Elevating the Icon

CHANDRADEEP KUMAR

Nestled in the scenic hills of Ekta Nagar, the Statue of Unity (SOU), the world's tallest statue, which honours Sardar Vallabhbhai Patel, is set to become an even more captivating destination, with new facilities on the horizon. A scenic trekking trail winding through the lush hills surrounding the SOU is in the works. Announced as part of a major tourism upgrade in August 2025, these new paths aim to weave adventure seamlessly into the site's iconic landscape.

Designed for both thrill-seekers and casual hikers, the paths will feature well-marked tracks with moderate inclines, panoramic viewpoints of the Sardar Sarovar Dam, and interpretive signs highlighting local flora, fauna, and Sardar Patel's legacy. Adding to the allure, a replica of the Sardar Sarovar Dam will soon grace the entrance of the SOU campus. This miniature marvel will offer a glimpse into the engineering feat that powers the region, enriching the educational aspect of the visit.

To elevate the SOU as a premier tourist hub, a vibrant hospitality district is being planned. This area will feature a range of accommodations, from cozy lodges to upscale retreats, catering to both domestic and international travellers. The district aims to ensure visitors can extend their stay, soak in the serene ambience and explore the site at their own pace. Plans are also underway to expedite the development of these facilities, ensuring they meet global standards of comfort and convenience.

— Jumana Shah



HERITAGE MEETS HOSPITALITY

A stately art deco mansion in Uttar Pradesh has become the 150th offering of amã Stays & Trails, IHCL's premium homestay vertical. Built in 1929, Anand Bhawan Palace, Tirwa, Kannauj, has been restored beautifully. It now offers six spacious suites, each named after a timeless perfume of Kannauj—the Yasmine Suite, the Patchouli Suite, the Oudh Suite, the Neroli Suite, the Gulaab Suite and the Bakhoor Suite. Highlights include farm-to-table dining, intimate barbecue nights under the stars, a vintage billiards room, birdwatching at the nearby sanctuary and, of course, an exploration of Kannauj's famed attar-making traditions.

From Rs 25,200 per night plus taxes, www.amastaysandtrails.com